

Astronomy of the Solar System AST 101

AST101 CRN 20743 – 4 credits – Spring 2026

Class modality: in person, on campus

Meeting times: Mondays 9:30-10:45am (T-201), Wednesdays 9:30-10:45am and 10:50am-12:40pm (T-201)

Professor: Dr Glenda Denicoló

Email: denicog@sunysuffolk.edu (email is the best way to contact me)

Office hours (office T-218): Mon Tue Wed Thu 8:30-9:30am, Mon 11-12pm.

Tutoring: free tutoring is available in T-210. Check the schedule posted at the door of T-210, and in D2L.

Textbook: Astronomy by OpenStax (free digital copy) <https://openstax.org/details/books/astronomy-2e>

Required for Labs and HW: Registration link inside D2L. Cost: \$10/semester/student.

Other required materials: always bring a Scientific Calculator. No cell phones will be accepted as calculators.

Supplementary materials: freely available as slides and links in D2L.

Cell phone: please stow it away during class.

Catalog Description

Introduction to fundamental aspects of planetary science. Topics include historical development of astronomy; basic concepts of celestial coordinates and motions; properties and individual characteristics of planets and their moons, asteroids, comets and meteoroids; and origin and evolution of the solar system. Students also learn to identify celestial objects (constellations, prominent stars, planets, etc.) utilizing planetarium, telescopes and unaided eye. Occasional evening observations required. Note: Fulfills SUNY-GE Natural Sciences. (3 hrs. lecture, 2 hrs. laboratory) Prerequisite: MAT007 or equivalent. Offered on: A-E-G / 4 cr. hrs.

Course Learning Outcomes

Upon completion of this course, students will be able to:

1. Use measurements and astronomical data to describe the solar system.
2. Summarize how the scientific method applies to astronomy.
3. Use the horizon system to locate prominent stars and constellations.
4. Compare the fundamental properties of planets to Earth and each other.
5. Evaluate the Sun's influence on the planets of the solar system.
6. Relate the properties of the solar system to the solar nebula theory.
7. Discuss recent developments in the field of astronomy.

Grade Policy

Item	Grade weight
Labs (13 – 3 lowest = 10; or 3 points each) – no make-up!	30%
Homework (10 – 2 lowest = 8) – no make-up!	13%
Non-cumulative Tests (3; 15 points each) – no make-up!	45%
Optional cumulative Final Test (can replace lowest Test if taken)	(15%)
Planetarium Test – no make-up!	10%
Class attendance (> 90%, or 0-2 missed classes)	1%
Pre- and post-instruction assessments, together	1%
<i>EXTRA: 5-min presentation at the end of the semester</i>	<i>2%</i>
<i>EXTRA: Attending an observing night or talk at SCCC or SBU (1)</i>	<i>1%</i>
Total =	103% !!

The final course grade will be a combination of the 10 best labs and 8 best homework grades, 3 tests (if Final Test is taken, it can substitute the lowest grade of one of the first 3 tests), 1 planetarium test, class attendance, and completion of course assessments. Optionally, students can be awarded extra credits by giving a 5-min presentation at the end of the semester (see schedule), and by attending an observing night or talk (see information in D2L). No other form of extra credit will be given.

There is **no make-up for a missed Test, without exception**, because the lowest grade among all 4 tests is dropped and only 3 are used to compute the final grade. If a student misses one of the initial 3 tests, the students should take the cumulative Final Test to replace the missed one.

There are **no make-ups for missed Labs or Homework, without exception**, because several of the lowest grades (3 lowest for Labs, and 2 lowest for HW) are dropped. Once the deadline for submission has passed, students will be able to access solutions even if the activity was missed, in order to study for Tests.

Grades will always be posted in D2L. Student must check grades regularly. If there are any inconsistency or questions, **consult the instructor within a week.** Do not leave problems or questions to the last week of the semester. Issues must be reported immediately.

***Reach out and speak up as soon as possible when/if an issue comes up.
Communications of extenuating circumstances done only at the end of the semester will have no effect.***

89.5 ≤ A ≤ 100

84.5 ≤ B+ ≤ 89.4

79.5 ≤ B ≤ 84.4

There will be NO curving of the grades in this course (i.e., the curving is done by the student when completing extra credit assignments). Your final grade is non-negotiable. The letter grade breakdown that will be used is shown on the right.

74.5 ≤ C+ ≤ 79.4

69.5 ≤ C ≤ 74.4

64.5 ≤ D+ ≤ 69.4

According to the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA), grades will never be discussed via e-mail or phone, only in person. Always check your grades in D2L.

59.5 ≤ D ≤ 64.4

F ≤ 59.4

Lab activities policy

There are 13 lab activities that **must be completed while working in groups in class, and must be submitted in class** (this is not an online lab class, no remote lab work will be accepted). Everyone in the same group will receive the same grade. However, *if a member of the group departs before the submission of the lab, that group member will be given zero for that lab activity.*

There is **no make-up for the labs** because the 3 lowest lab grades will be dropped at the end of the semester.

Links to lab activities are available inside D2L/Brightspace.

Students are welcome to bring their own computer device if they wish (**no tablets or cell phones** should be used, as they will *not* display the lab information correctly), but **school laptops will also be available**. No installation is necessary, as PivotInteractives **runs in a browser**. Preferred browsers are Chrome, Firefox, or Safari.

The cost to use PivotInteractives is \$10 for the entire semester per student (payment is required at registration). **The registration link is available inside D2L:** enter our astronomy course page, then click “Content” (top menu), and find the link inside “PivotInteractives REGISTRATION” (menu on the left).

Solutions and corrections will be available within a week of the submission of the lab. Lab grades will also be posted in D2L. **Students should consult the graded labs to study for Tests.**

Homework assignments policy

Homework assignments are available inside Pivot Interactives like the Lab activities; there is no additional cost.

Homework assignments must be **completed INDIVIDUALLY** before each deadline (see detailed schedule in this document). HW can be completed remotely outside of class time, and is *not* group work.

There is **no make-up for HW** because the 2 lowest grades will be dropped at the end of the semester.

Solutions and corrections will be available within a week of the submission of the HW. Grades will also be posted in D2L. **Students should consult the graded HW to study for Tests.**

Planetarium

There will be one Planetarium Test at the end of the semester worth 10% of the final grade.

Students are encouraged to access the planetarium room (**always complete the sign-in sheet at the door**) during the semester to practice for this test. In D2L, students can find the explanation of the remote-control used in the planetarium, and the list of constellations, asterisms and stars that will be asked in the Planetarium Test.

If the planetarium room is locked, students can ask access to any astronomy faculty available (my office is 218), or to Mrs. Deanna Downs (office 220), or book a time in advance.

During the semester, the instructor will visit the planetarium a few times with the students to guide them through the material that will be asked in the Planetarium Test.

Our attendance policy

(also check the College Policies included in this document)

Due to the nature and amount of the material in this course, it is crucial that each student attend every lecture and laboratory session.

In our course, students will be awarded 1 point in their final grade if they miss only 0-2 classes per semester, which corresponds to more than 90% attendance. Anyone who misses more than 2 classes will not be awarded the attendance point, without any exception, even if there is a valid excuse. In that case, the

student must take advantage of other opportunities (such as extra credit assignments) to make-up for the missed attendance point.

Students missing classes must contact the instructor as soon as possible to learn about any updates or announcements that may have happened during the missed class. **It is the student's responsibility to reach out as soon as possible.**

Withdrawal policy

(also check the College Policies included in this document)

Students can withdraw by completing a form and submitting it to the registrar's office by **Tuesday April 14, 2026** (deadline). It is common *courtesy to previously communicate to your instructor that you intend to leave the course*. <https://www.sunysuffolk.edu/current-students/registrar/withdrawal.jsp>

Only students who submit a course withdrawal form on or before the deadline are guaranteed a W.

Withdrawals after the deadline can only be done in extreme cases such as medical leave or extended jury duty, and never along the lines "I am failing the class, thus I wish to withdraw at this late stage". W requests after the deadline are judged by a college dean, not by the instructor.

Please note that **if you stop attending class without officially withdrawing, you will receive an F at the end of the semester**. It is important to know also that the instructor has no means to give you a W at the end of the semester (this option is not available in the school system when entering the final grades). **Withdrawal is an action started by the student** and it must go through the registrar's office before the W deadline.

College Policies

Class Attendance Policy

Regular attendance is considered essential for academic success. Students are expected to attend every class session, no matter the modality, of each course for which they are registered. Students absent from a class for any reason are responsible for any missed work and any other relevant requirements stated in the course syllabus.

Students are allowed the equivalent of one week worth of absences, which includes absences due to illness or other unforeseen circumstance. Students unable to attend class or participate in an online class should contact their professor immediately as this can negatively impact their grade or enrollment status in the course.

In-person and Synchronous (Real-time/Combined) Classes:

- For classes that meet twice per week during a 15-week term, students are allowed at least two absences.
- The number of permitted absences may vary depending on the length of the term.
- Additional absences may be allowed at the discretion of the instructor, based on specific class policies.

Online Classes (Asynchronous/Blended):

- The College defines attendance in online courses as regular participation in course-related activities, which may include, but is not limited to: contributing to online discussion, engaging in virtual live instruction (when applicable), submitting an assignment, taking a quiz or exam, viewing and/or completing a tutorial, or communicating with a faculty member regarding course content.
- Logging into an online class is not sufficient, by itself, to demonstrate attendance or participation by the student.

Religious Observance Policies and Procedures: As provided for in New York State Education Law § 224-a, student absences from class necessitated by religious observance will be deemed an excused absence, with no negative academic consequences. Students must notify their professor as far in advance of their religious observance as possible, via their college email account or otherwise in writing, of their intention to be absent from a particular class due to a religious observance; notification should occur at least one week prior to the religious observance.

While the College will consider all student religious observance or religious accommodation requests, accommodation of a request that would fundamentally alter the nature or operations of the course or program of study, or that would result in a significant number of absences within a course or substantially impact class participation requirements, may not be reasonable or feasible. If a request involves an alternate exam date or time, students should expect that any make-up exam given for purposes of exam security must be comparable, in terms of format and difficulty, to the exams given to the other students enrolled in the course. Observing students shall be granted reasonable arrangements and/or be permitted a reasonable amount of time to make up missed quizzes, tests, assignments, and activities covered in their absence.

Course Withdrawal Policy

A student may withdraw from a course and receive a W any time between the end of the add/drop period and the withdrawal deadline, which is the end of two-thirds of the part of term.

After this deadline, a student may appeal to the Campus Associate Dean of Academic Affairs for a course withdrawal if the student has experienced unforeseen or extenuating circumstances. The student must obtain an acknowledgment from the faculty via signature and then submit the Appeal for Course Withdrawal form to the Campus Associate Dean of Academic Affairs no later than:

- For the 15 week-term, seven business days before end of term.
- For the 10-week term, five business days before the end of term.
- For terms less than 10 weeks, three business days before the end of term.

If a student drops a course(s) prior to the end of the add/drop period, the student's academic record will not reflect these courses. After the end of the add/drop period, if a student is officially withdrawn from a course, a "W" will be reflected for that course on their academic record. Withdrawal from a course is considered an "unsuccessful course attempt" and may negatively impact financial aid and satisfactory progress requirements.

Official withdrawal from the College means that a student voluntarily separates from the College by dropping all courses at any time during the academic term.

Withdrawal forms can be found on the college website.

For Spring 2026, the deadline to submit a Course Withdrawal for 15-week Full Term, Saturday and Sunday parts of term classes and be guaranteed a W is April 14, 2026.

NOTE: An exception to the Withdrawal Policy is when a student is seeking a [medical withdrawal](#). This action is managed exclusively through the Campus Associate Dean of Student Affairs office and requires medical documentation for consideration.

Academic Integrity

Suffolk County Community College provides students with the opportunity to demonstrate their knowledge by submitting coursework that is uniquely theirs and giving proper attribution to the work of others. Participating honestly in the SCCC academic community ensures that students can take pride in their education and their contributions to scholarship. Without academic integrity, students gain unfair advantage over others and prevent their own intellectual progress. As a student in this class, you are expected to uphold the SCCC core value of Integrity and understand the Special Procedures for Academic Dishonesty in the relevant sections of the [SCCC Student Code of Conduct](#).

The Code prohibits academic misconduct, which includes any action that results in students giving or receiving unauthorized assistance in an academic exercise, or receiving credit for work that is not their own. Academic exercise includes all forms of work submitted for credit. Academic misconduct includes, but is not limited to, the following behaviors: cheating (unauthorized use of textbooks, notes, mobile devices, artificial intelligence tools or other sources during an academic exercise); plagiarizing (using another person's work or ideas without crediting them, including using material generated by artificial intelligence tools for an assignment without instructor authorization); complicity (helping a student, or being helped, to engage in academic misconduct); multiple submissions (submitting the same work for credit in more than one course without the instructor's permission); falsification and forgery (inventing information or falsifying the identity of a student).

Information about the Student Code of Conduct, plagiarism and the citation process is in the [Academic Integrity](#) webpage.

Services for Students with Disabilities

Suffolk County Community College provides reasonable accommodations to registered students with disabilities who have self-identified and been approved by the Office of Disability Services. Once approved for reasonable accommodations, such students will be provided with an Accommodation Letter, describing the specific accommodations. Students must present this letter to each of their professors before accommodations can be provided. Students are encouraged to email this letter to their faculty member.

Students who have, or think they may have, a disability are invited to contact Disability Services for a confidential consultation. Students are encouraged to contact the office by email this semester.

Disability Services Contact Information

Ammerman Campus

Call 631-451-4045 or email the Office at disabilityA@sunysuffolk.edu

Eastern Campus

Call 631-548-2527 or email the Office at disabilityE@sunysuffolk.edu

Michael J. Grant Campus

Call 631-851-6355 or email the Office at disabilityG@sunysuffolk.edu

Reasonable Modifications and Anti-Discrimination for Student Pregnancy or Related Conditions

Suffolk County Community College is committed to creating an accessible and inclusive environment for all students. Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972 prohibits sex discrimination, including discrimination

and harassment against students on the basis of *current, potential, or past* pregnancy or related conditions with respect to the College's education programs and activities. Pregnancy or related conditions will be treated in the same manner and under the same policies and practices as any other temporary medical condition. Students who are pregnant or have pregnancy-related conditions may request reasonable modifications when necessary, by contacting one of the College's Deputy Title IX Coordinators. More information can be found in the Student Handbook and in the College's [procedure](#) on reasonable accommodations for student pregnancy.

Preventing Spread of Respiratory Viruses When You are Sick

Current precautions recommend that if you have [symptoms of common respiratory viruses](#) such as COVID-19, flu, and RSV, that aren't better explained by another cause, you may be contagious and should stay home and away from others. Students can return to normal activities when their symptoms have been improving for at least 24 hours, and, if they had a fever, when their fever has been gone without use of fever-reducing medication for at least 24 hours. After returning to normal activities, you should continue to take added precaution using prevention strategies such as wearing a well-fitting mask for the next 5 days, enhancing hygiene practices, keeping a distance from others, and/or testing when you will be around other people indoors. If you never had symptoms but tested positive for a respiratory virus, you may be contagious and should take the same added precautions for the next 5 days when you will be around other people indoors. If you develop a fever or start to feel worse after you have gone back to normal activities, the CDC recommends you follow the stay home precaution outlined above again before returning to normal activities.

Respect and Civility

In alignment with our institutional mission and strong support of diversity, equity and inclusion, Suffolk County Community College reaffirms its commitment to providing access to higher education and a welcome environment to all students. No matter your age, race, ethnicity, national origin, gender identity or expression, sexual orientation, family status, U.S. citizenship status, religion, socio-economic status, political ideology, military-connected status, or intellectual or physical ability - you belong here. Therefore, in this class, we will maintain an atmosphere of mutual respect, civil discourse and cross-cultural communication.

The College prohibits discrimination and harassment, and ensures equal opportunity. You can read more at: www.sunysuffolk.edu/nondiscrimination.

Mental Health & Wellness Services (MHWS)

SUNY Suffolk understands that your academic success goes hand-in-hand with your mental health and well-being. We want you to know that if you ever need support for your emotional, psychological, or social well-being, our Mental Health & Wellness Services counselors are here for you. Counseling services are free and completely confidential. For more information about MHWS and our events this semester, visit our website: [SUNY Suffolk Mental Health Services](#) or follow us on Instagram @SCCCMentalHealth.

To schedule an appointment with one of our licensed mental health professionals, you can email MHWS at mentalhealth@sunysuffolk.edu or give your campus MHWS office a call.

Ammerman Campus: 631-451-4040

Eastern Campus: 631-548-2650

Michael J. Grant Campus: 631-451-4040

AST101 CRN 20743 Mon 9:30-10:45 (T-201), Wed 9:30-10:45, 10:50-12:40 (T-201)

W	Date	HW # due	Activity	Textbook Chapter/Section
1	Mon Jan 26		Introduction to AST101; <i>Pre-instruction assessment to evaluate the course</i>	
	Wed Jan 28		Brief overview of astronomy Lab 1: Planetarium with https://stellarium-web.org/ ; Planetarium room	1
2	Mon Feb 2		Scales, the universe in powers of ten, units, constellations, horizon system	2.1, 4.1, App C, D
	Wed Feb 4	1	Patterns and cycles in the sky, seasons Lab 2: Overview of mathematical and scientific tools	2.1, 4.1-4.2
3	Mon Feb 9		Basic properties of light, electromagnetic spectrum	5
	Wed Feb 11	2	Atomic transitions, types of astronomical spectra Lab 3: Basic coordinates and seasons	5
4	Mon Feb 16		<i>No class – President's Day</i>	
	Wed Feb 18		Doppler effect, astronomical instruments Lab 4: The horizon system and analyzing the rotating sky	5, 6.2, 6.5
5	Mon Feb 23	3	Test 1 (1:15 min)	Study slides in D2L
	Wed Feb 25		Early models of the solar system, Kepler's laws Lab 5: Planetary orbits – Part 1	2
6	Mon Mar 2		Scientific method, Newton's laws	3
	Wed Mar 4	4	Gravity, angular momentum, energy Lab 6: Planetary orbits – Part 2	3
7	Mon Mar 9		The Moon	9.1-9.4
	Wed Mar 11	5	The Moon Lab 7: Planetary orbits – Part 3	9.1-9.4, 4.5-4.7
8	SPRING BREAK			
9	Mon Mar 23		The Sun	15, 16
	Wed Mar 25		The Sun Lab 8: Lunar phases – Part 1	15, 16
10	Mon Mar 30		The Sun	15, 16
	Wed Apr 1	6	Formation of solar system Lab 9: Lunar phases – Part 2	7.1-7.2, 7.4, 14.3
11	Mon Apr 6	7	Test 2 (1:15 min)	Study slides in D2L
	Wed Apr 8		Planetary geology Lab 10: The Sun	7.1-7.2, 8.2, 10.1
12	Mon Apr 13		Planetary geology – April 14 is the withdrawal deadline	7.1-7.2, 8.2, 10.1
	Wed Apr 15	8	Planetary atmospheres Lab 11: Craters on planetary surfaces; Planetarium room	8.3, 10.3, 10.5-10.6, 11.3
13	Mon Apr 20		Mercury	9.5
	Wed Apr 22		Venus, Mars Lab 12: Solar system properties; Planetarium room	10.1-10.4
14	Mon Apr 27		Mars, meteorites	10.4-10.6, 14.1-14.2
	Wed Apr 29	9	Asteroids, comets Lab 13: Atmospheric retention	13
15	Mon May 4		Jovian planets	11
	Wed May 6		Jovian planets, their moons, and the Kuiper Belt	11, 12
16	Mon May 11		<i>Post-instruction assessment to evaluate the course. Extra credit presentations.</i>	
	Wed May 13	10	Planetarium Test; Test 3 (1:15 min)	Study slides in D2L
17	Mon May 18		Optional cumulative Final Test (1:15 min)	

The current schedule is subject to changes due to any class cancellations or adjustments. Students must attend class to learn about any changes, or must email instructor immediately to learn, in case a class is missed.

DISCLAIMER

General rules are posted in your course outline. But even if a rule is not specifically shown in your course outline, it may be announced only in class and it is a valid new rule that must be followed. If there are changes to any existing rules, these too will be announced in class whether or not they are in print.

Students are responsible for apprising themselves of anything that transpires in class whether or not they are in attendance. All students need to be aware of all announcements whether or not they are in attendance: 1) ask another student; 2) e-mail the professor and ask to update you on any new announcements. If you missed a class, you must ask: it is YOUR responsibility to ask.

Professors are not “babysitters”, i.e., they will not remind you all the time of the requirements presented in the course outline: you have the responsibility to know what is strictly expected from you. If you miss a deadline, it’s on you. Print/take a photo of the detailed schedule and have it handy at all times.

All students are personally accountable for all submitted work. You must keep track of your own progress in class. Learn where to check your grades and your calculated final grade at all times (it’s in the gradebook in D2L!); estimate your own final grade to know where you are heading. This only requires basic knowledge of math: ask for help if needed. Ask for help at the start of the semester, do not let problems linger.

YOU are responsible for the grade you receive.

Professors are just messengers in the classroom: the grade you get is not “given” by the professor – it is the grade that you gave to yourself, the grade that you have earned, in direct correspondence to how much YOU have studied, worked and learned about the subject. Taking responsibility for your own acts and taking responsibility for your own work is a good rule for life.

cut here ✂

cut here ✂

cut here ✂

Return this signed slip to the professor by the 2nd class meeting.

I have read and am aware of all the information contained in the course outline of AST101.

Date: ____/____/____

Name (please print): _____

Your signature: _____